Cold Email Infrastructure Setup Checklist

The exact checklist I follow on every setup — domains, mailboxes, authentication, warm-up and handover. By Muhammad Athar, Cold Email Infrastructure Specialist.

1. Domains

- ■ Primary domain is NEVER used for cold outreach
- ■ Secondary domains selected (similar to the main brand, trustworthy TLD)
- ■ Domains purchased and DNS access confirmed

2. Mailboxes

- ■ Mailboxes created on Google Workspace or Microsoft 365
- ■ Consistent naming (first name / first+last) across all inboxes
- ■ Profile details set for each inbox; sending limits noted (per-inbox daily cap)

3. DNS & Authentication

- ■ SPF record published — exactly ONE SPF record per domain
- ■ DKIM enabled and record published for every mailbox domain
- ■ DMARC record published (start at p=none, monitor, then tighten)
- ■ MX records correct and verified
- ■ Custom tracking domain configured and verified

4. Sending Tool Setup

- ■ Inboxes connected to Instantly or Smartlead
- ■ Warm-up enabled for every inbox
- ■ Sending limits and ramp-up schedule configured
- ■ Custom tracking domain active inside the tool

5. Warm-Up Rules

- ■ Warm-up runs at least 14–21 days before any campaign
- ■ Warm-up stays ON during campaigns — never switched off
- ■ Volume ramps gradually; no full-volume sending from day one

6. Pre-Launch Checks

- ■ DNS propagation confirmed (records live, not just saved)
- ■ SPF / DKIM / DMARC all PASS alignment checks (e.g. MxToolbox)
- ■ Google Postmaster Tools connected for the domains
- ■ Test emails land correctly before launch

7. Handover

- ■ Domain and inbox list documented (which inbox belongs to which domain)
- ■ All records and settings listed in one handover document
- ■ Client knows what to monitor after launch (bounces, replies, spam signals)

Want this done for your agency or business? DM me “AUDIT” on LinkedIn for a free deliverability check of one domain — SPF, DKIM, DMARC, tracking domain and warm-up status — with a short written summary. Muhammad Athar · linkedin.com/in/muhammad-athar-coldemail